

Jimmy pursed up his lips.

‘Heart?’ he hazarded.

Ronny gave a short, scornful laugh.

‘I say, Ronny,’ said Jimmy.

‘Well?’

Jimmy found a difficulty in going on.

‘You don’t mean—you aren’t thinking—I mean, you haven’t got it into your head that—that, well, I mean he wasn’t biffed on the head or anything? Tredwell’s locking the door and all that.’

It seemed to Jimmy that his words deserved an answer, but Ronny continued to stare straight out in front of him.

Jimmy shook his head and relapsed into silence. He didn’t see that there was anything to do except just wait. So he waited.

It was Tredwell who disturbed them.

‘The doctor would like to see you two gentlemen in the library, if you please, sir.’

Ronny sprang up. Jimmy followed him.

Dr Cartwright was a thin, energetic young man with a clever face. He greeted them with a brief nod. Pongo, looking more serious and spectacled than ever, performed introductions.

‘I understand you were a great friend of Mr Wade’s,’ the doctor said to Ronny.

‘His greatest friend.’

‘H’m. Well, this business seems straightforward enough. Sad, though. He looked a healthy young chap. Do you know if he was in the habit of taking stuff to make him sleep?’

‘Make him *sleep*?’ Ronny stared. ‘He always slept like a top.’

‘You never heard him complain of sleeplessness?’

‘Never.’

‘Well, the facts are simple enough. There’ll have to be an inquest, I’m afraid, nevertheless.’

‘How did he die?’

‘There’s not much doubt; I should say an overdose of chloral. The stuff was by his bed. And a bottle and glass. Very sad, these things are.’

It was Jimmy who asked the question which he felt was trembling on his friend’s lips, and yet which the other could somehow or other not get out.

‘There’s no question of—foul play?’

The doctor looked at him sharply.

‘Why do you say that? Any cause to suspect it, eh?’

Jimmy looked at Ronny. If Ronny knew anything, now was the time to speak. But to his astonishment Ronny shook his head.

‘No cause whatever,’ he said clearly.

‘And suicide—eh?’

‘Certainly not.’

Ronny was emphatic. The doctor was not so clearly convinced.

‘No troubles that you know of? Money troubles? A woman?’

Again Ronny shook his head.

‘Now about his relations. They must be notified.’

‘He’s got a sister—a half-sister rather. Lives at Deane Priory. About twenty miles from here. When he wasn’t in town Gerry lived with her.’

‘H’m,’ said the doctor. ‘Well, she must be told.’

‘I’ll go,’ said Ronny. ‘It’s a rotten job, but somebody’s got to do it.’ He looked at Jimmy. ‘You know her, don’t you?’

‘Slightly. I’ve danced with her once or twice.’

‘Then we’ll go in your car. You don’t mind, do you? I can’t face it alone.’

‘That’s all right,’ said Jimmy reassuringly. ‘I was going to suggest it myself. I’ll go and get the old bus cranked up.’

He was glad to have something to do. Ronny’s manner puzzled him. What did he know or suspect? And why had he not voiced his suspicions, if he had them, to the doctor.

Presently the two friends were skimming along in Jimmy’s car with a cheerful disregard for such things as speed limits.

‘Jimmy,’ said Ronny at last, ‘I suppose you’re about the best pal I have—now.’

‘Well,’ said Jimmy, ‘what about it?’

He spoke gruffly.

‘There’s something I’d like to tell you. Something you ought to know.’

‘About Gerry Wade?’

‘Yes, about Gerry Wade.’

Jimmy waited.

‘Well?’ he inquired at last.

‘I don’t know that I ought to,’ said Ronny.

‘Why?’

‘I’m bound by a kind of promise.’

‘Oh! Well then, perhaps you’d better not.’

There was a silence.

‘And yet, I’d like—You see, Jimmy, your brains are better than mine.’

‘They could easily be that,’ said Jimmy unkindly.

‘No, I can’t,’ said Ronny suddenly.

‘All right,’ said Jimmy. ‘Just as you like.’

After a long silence, Ronny said:

‘What’s she like?’

‘Who?’

‘This girl, Gerry’s sister.’

Jimmy was silent for some minutes, then he said in a voice that had somehow or other altered:

‘She’s all right. In fact—well, she’s a corker.’

‘Gerry was very devoted to her, I know. He often spoke of her.’

‘She was very devoted to Gerry. It—it’s going to hit her hard.’

‘Yes, a nasty job.’

They were silent till they reached Deane Priory.

Miss Lorraine, the maid told them, was in the garden. Unless they wanted

to see Mrs Coker—

Jimmy was eloquent that they did not want to see Mrs Coker.

‘Who’s Mrs Coker?’ asked Ronny as they went round into the somewhat neglected garden.

‘The old trout who lives with Lorraine.’

They had stepped out into a paved walk. At the end of it was a girl with two black spaniels. A small girl, very fair, dressed in shabby old tweeds. Not at all the girl that Ronny had expected to see. Not, in fact, Jimmy’s usual type. Holding one dog by the collar, she came down the pathway to meet them. ‘How do you do,’ she said. ‘You musn’t mind Elizabeth. She’s just had some puppies and she’s very suspicious.’

Tredwell’s eyes wandered from him to Jimmy Theisger and then back again. As though singled out, the two young men left the room with him. Tredwell closed the dining-room door carefully behind him.

‘Well,’ said Ronny. ‘What’s up?’

‘Mr Wade not having yet come down, sir, I took the liberty of sending Williams up to his room.’

‘Yes.’

‘Williams has just come running down in a great state of agitation, sir,’ Tredwell paused—a pause of preparation. ‘I am afraid, sir, the poor young gentleman must have died in his sleep.’

Jimmy and Ronny stared at him.

‘Nonsense,’ cried Ronny at last. ‘It’s—it’s impossible. Gerry—’ His face worked suddenly. ‘I’ll—I’ll run up and see. That fool Williams may have made a mistake.’

Tredwell stretched out a detaining hand. With a queer, unnatural feeling of detachment, Jimmy realized that the butler had the whole situation in hand.

‘No, sir, Williams has made no mistake. I have already sent for Dr Cartwright, and in the meantime I have taken the liberty of locking the door, preparatory to informing Sir Oswald of what has occurred. I must now find Mr Bateman.’

Tredwell hurried away. Ronny stood like a man dazed.

‘Gerry,’ he muttered to himself.

Jimmy took his friend by the arm and steered him out through a side door on to a secluded portion of the terrace. He pushed him down on to a seat.

‘Take it easy, old son,’ he said kindly. ‘You’ll get your wind in a minute.’

But he looked at him rather curiously. He had had no idea that Ronny was such a friend of Gerry Wade’s.

‘Poor old Gerry,’ he said thoughtfully. ‘If ever a man looked fit, he did.’

Ronny nodded.

‘All that clock business seems so rotten now,’ went on Jimmy. ‘It’s odd, isn’t it, why farce so often seems to get mixed up with tragedy?’

He was talking more or less at random, to give Ronny time to recover himself. The other moved restlessly.

‘I wish that doctor would come. I want to know—’

‘Know what?’

‘What he—died of.’

'Well, if you ask me,' said Socks, 'I think he's just spoofing us. Of course they woke him up. But he's just going to do us down by pretending that he didn't hear anything.'

Every one looked at Socks with respect and admiration.

'It's an idea,' said Bill.

'He's subtle, that's what it is,' said Socks. 'You'll see, he'll be extra late for breakfast this morning—just to show us.'

And since the clock now pointed to some minutes past twelve the general opinion was that Socks' theory was a correct one. Only Ronny Devereux demurred.

'You forget, I was outside the door when the first one went off. Whatever old Gerry decided to do later, the first one must have surprised him. He'd have let out something about it. Where did you put it, Pongo?'

'On a little table close to his ear,' said Mr Bateman.

'That was thoughtful of you, Pongo,' said Ronny. 'Now, tell me.' He turned to Bill. 'If a whacking great bell started ringing within a few inches of your ear at half-past six in the morning, what would you say about it?'

'Oh! Lord,' said Bill. 'I should say—' He came to a stop.

'Of course you would,' said Ronny. 'So should I. So would anyone. What they call the natural man would emerge. Well, it didn't. So I say that Pongo is right—as usual—and that Gerry has got an obscure disease of the ear-drums.'

'It's now twenty past twelve,' said one of the other girls sadly.

'I say,' said Jimmy slowly, 'that's a bit beyond anything, isn't it? I mean a joke's a joke. But this is carrying it a bit far. It's a shade hard on the Cootes.' Bill stared at him.

'What are you getting at?'

'Well,' said Jimmy, 'somehow or other—it's not like old Gerry.'

He found it hard to put into words just what he meant to say. He didn't want to say too much, and yet—He saw Ronny looking at him. Ronny was suddenly alert.

It was at that moment Tiredwell came into the room and looked round him hesitatingly.

'I thought Mr Bateman was here,' he explained apologetically.

'Just gone out this minute through the window,' said Ronny. 'Can I do anything?'

She had a supremely natural manner and, as she looked up smiling, the faint wild rose flush deepened in her cheeks. Her eyes were a very dark blue—like cornflowers.

Suddenly they widened—was it with alarm? As though, already, she guessed. Jimmy hastened to speak.

'This is Ronny Devereux, Miss Wade. You must often have heard Gerry speak of him.'

'Oh! yes.' She turned a lovely, warm, welcoming smile on him. 'You've both been staying at Chimneys, haven't you? Why didn't you bring Gerry over with you?'

'We—er—couldn't,' said Ronny, and then stopped.

Again Jimmy saw the look of fear flash into her eyes.

'Miss Wade,' he said, 'I'm afraid—I mean, we've got bad news for you.'

She was on the alert in a moment.

'Gerry?'

'Yes—Gerry. He's—'

She stamped her foot with sudden passion.

'Oh! tell me—tell me—' She turned suddenly on Ronny. 'You'll tell me.' Jimmy felt a pang of jealousy, and in that moment he knew what up to now he had hesitated to admit to himself.

He knew why Helen and Nancy and Socks were just 'girls' to him and nothing more.

He only *half* heard Ronny's voice saying gravely:

'Yes, Miss Wade, I'll tell you. Gerry is dead.'

She had plenty of pluck. She gasped and drew back, but in a minute or two she was asking eager, searching questions. How? When?

Ronny answered her as gently as he could.

'*Sleeping* draught? Gerry?'

The incredulity in her voice was plain. Jimmy gave her a glance. It was almost a glance of warning. He had a sudden feeling that Lorraine in her innocence might say too much.

In his turn he explained as gently as possible the need for an inquest. She shuddered. She declined their offer of taking her back to Chimneys with them, but explained she would come over later. She had a two-seater of her own. 'But I want to be—be alone a little first,' she said pitiously.

'I know,' said Ronny.

'That's all right,' said Jimmy.

They looked at her, feeling awkward and helpless.

'Thank you both ever so much for coming.'

They drove back in silence and there was something like constraint between them.

'My God! that girl's plucky,' said Ronny once.

Jimmy agreed.

'Gerry was my friend,' said Ronny. 'It's up to me to keep an eye on her.'

'Oh! rather. Of course.'

They said no more.

On returning to Chimneys Jimmy was waylaid by a tearful Lady Coote.

'That poor boy,' she kept repeating. 'That poor boy.'

Jimmy made all the suitable remarks he could think of.

Lady Coote told him at great length various details about the decease of various dear friends of hers. Jimmy listened with a show of sympathy and at last managed to detach himself without actual rudeness.

He ran lightly up the stairs. Ronny was just emerging from Gerald Wade's room. He seemed taken aback at the sight of Jimmy.

'I've been in to see him,' he said. 'Are you going in?'

'I don't think so,' said Jimmy, who was a healthy young man with a natural dislike to being reminded of death.

'I think all his friends ought to.'

'Oh! do you?' said Jimmy, and registered to himself an impression that Ronny Devereux was damned odd about it all.

'Yes. It's a sign of respect.'

Jimmy sighed, but gave in.

'Oh! very well,' he said, and passed in, setting his teeth a little.

There were white flowers arranged on the coverlet, and the room had been tidied and set to rights.

Jimmy gave one quick, nervous glance at the still, white face. Could that be cherubic, pink Gerry Wade? That still peaceful figure. He shivered.

As he turned to leave the room, his glance swept the mantelshelf and he stopped in astonishment. The alarm clocks had been ranged along it neatly in a row.

Chapter III

The Joke That Failed

'TWELVE o'clock,' said Socks despairingly.

The joke—as a joke—had not gone off any too well. The alarm clocks, on the other hand, had performed their part. *They* had gone off—with a vigour and *élan* that could hardly have been surpassed and which had sent Ronny Devereux leaping out of bed with a confused idea that the day of judgment had come. If such had been the effect in the room next door, what must it have been at close quarters? Ronny hurried out in the passage and applied his ear to the crack of the door.

He expected profanity—expected it confidently and with intelligent anticipation. But he heard nothing at all. That is to say, he heard nothing of what he expected. The clocks were ticking all right—ticking in a loud, arrogant, exasperating manner. And presently another went off, ringing with a crude, deafening note that would have aroused acute irritation in a deaf man.

There was no doubt about it; the clocks had performed their part faithfully. They did all and more than Mr Murgatroyd had claimed for them. But apparently they had met their match in Gerald Wade.

The syndicate was inclined to be despondent about it.

'The lad isn't human,' grumbled Jimmy Thesiger.

'Probably thought he heard the telephone in the distance and rolled over and went to sleep again,' suggested Helen (or possibly Nancy).

'It seems to me very remarkable,' said Rupert Bareman seriously. 'I think he ought to see a doctor about it.'

'Some disease of the ear-drums,' suggested Bill hopefully.

Chapter 3: The Joke That Failed

He went out sharply. Ronny was waiting for him.

'Looks very peaceful and all that. Rotten luck on him,' mumbled Jimmy.

Then he said:

'I say, Ronny, who arranged all those clocks like that in a row?'

'How should I know? One of the servants, I suppose.'

'The funny thing is,' said Jimmy, 'that there are seven of them, not eight.'

One of them's missing. Did you notice that?'

Ronny made an inaudible sound.

'Seven instead of eight,' said Jimmy, frowning. 'I wonder why.'

Once more the clocks were solemnly assembled. Then another difficulty arose.

‘We can’t all go barging in. Make no end of a row. One person’s got to do it and the others can hand him the what-nots from the door.’

Hot discussion then arose as to the proper person to be selected.

The three girls were rejected on the grounds that they would giggle. Bill Eversleigh was rejected on the grounds of his height, weight and heavy tread, also for his general clumsiness, which latter clause he fiercely denied. Jimmy Theisger and Ronny Devereux were considered possibles, but in the end an overwhelming majority decided in favour of Rupert Bateman.

‘Pongo’s the lad,’ agreed Jimmy. ‘Anyway, he walks like a cat—always did. And then, if Gerry should waken up, Pongo will be able to think of some rotten silly thing to say to him. You know, something plausible that’ll calm him down and not rouse his suspicions.’

‘Something subtle,’ suggested the girl Socks thoughtfully.

‘Exactly,’ said Jimmy.

Pongo performed his job neatly and efficiently. Cautiously opening the bedroom door, he disappeared into the darkness inside bearing the two largest clocks. In a minute or two he reappeared on the threshold and two more were handed to him and then again twice more. Finally he emerged. Every one held his breath and listened. The rhythmical breathing of Gerald Wade could still be heard, but drowned, smothered and buried beneath the triumphant, impassioned ticking of Mr Murgatroyd’s eight alarum clocks.

‘Four tricks and the rubber,’ she announced. ‘I think I was very lucky to get four tricks there.’

‘Lucky,’ murmured Gerald Wade, as he pushed back his chair and came over to the fireplace to join the others. ‘Lucky, she calls it. That woman wants watching.’

Lady Coote was gathering up notes and silver.

‘I know I’m not a good player,’ she announced in a mournful tone which nevertheless held an undercurrent of pleasure in it. ‘But I’m really very lucky at the game.’

‘You’ll never be a bridge player, Maria,’ said Sir Oswald.

‘No, dear,’ said Lady Coote. ‘I know I shan’t. You’re always telling me so. And I do try so hard.’

‘She does,’ said Gerald Wade *sotto voce*. ‘There’s no subterfuge about it. She’d put her head right down on your shoulder if she couldn’t see into your hand any other way.’

‘I know you try,’ said Sir Oswald. ‘It’s just that you haven’t any card sense.’

‘I know, dear,’ said Lady Coote. ‘That’s what you’re always telling me. And you owe me another ten shillings, Oswald.’

‘Do I?’ Sir Oswald looked surprised.

‘Yes. Seventeen hundred—eight pounds ten. You’ve only given me eight pounds.’

‘Dear me,’ said Sir Oswald. ‘My mistake.’

Lady Coote smiled at him sadly and took up the extra ten-shilling note. She was very fond of her husband, but she had no intention of allowing him to cheat her out of ten shillings.

Sir Oswald moved over to a side table and became hospitable with whisky and soda. It was half-past twelve when general good-nights were said.

Ronny Devercux, who had the room next door to Gerald Wade’s, was told off to report progress. At a quarter to two he crept round tapping at doors. The party, pyjamaed and dressing-gowned, assembled with various scuffles and giggles and low whispers.

‘His light went out about twenty minutes ago,’ reported Ronny in a hoarse whisper. ‘I thought he’d never put it out. I opened the door just now and peeped in, and he seems sound off. What about it?’

Chapter IV

A Letter

‘INCONSIDERATE, that’s what I call it,’ said Lord Caterham.

IF He spoke in a gentle, plaintive voice and seemed pleased with the adjective he had found.

‘Yes, distinctly inconsiderate. I often find these self-made men *are* inconsiderate. Very possibly that is why they amass such large fortunes.’

He looked mournfully out over his ancestral acres, of which he had to-day regained possession.

His daughter, Lady Eileen Brent, known to her friends and society in general as ‘Bundle,’ laughed.

‘You’ll certainly never amass a large fortune,’ she observed dryly, ‘though you didn’t do so badly out of old Coote, sticking him for this place. What was he like? Presentable?’

‘One of those large men,’ said Lord Caterham, shuddering slightly, ‘with a red square face and iron-grey hair. Powerful, you know. What they call a forceful personality. The kind of a man you’d get if a steam-roller were turned into a human being.’

‘Rather tiring?’ suggested Bundle sympathetically.

‘Frightfully tiring, full of all the most depressing virtues like sobriety and punctuality. I don’t know which are the worst, powerful personalities or earnest politicians. I do so prefer the cheerful inefficient.’

‘A cheerful inefficient wouldn’t have been able to pay you the price you asked for this old mausoleum,’ Bundle reminded him.

Lord Caterham winced.

‘I wish you wouldn’t use that word, Bundle. We were just getting away from the subject.’

'I don't see why you're so frightfully sensitive about it,' said Bundle. 'After all, people must die somewhere.'

'They needn't die in my house,' said Lord Caterham.

'I don't see why not. Lots of people have. Masses of stuffy old great grand-fathers and grandmothers.'

'That's different,' said Lord Caterham. 'Naturally I expect Brents to die here—they don't count. But I do object to strangers. And I especially object to inquests. The thing will become a habit soon. This is the second. You remember all that fuss we had four years ago? For which, by the way, I hold George Lomax entirely to blame.'

'And now you're blaming poor old steam-roller Coote. I'm sure he was quite as annoyed about it as anyone.'

'Very inconsiderate,' said Lord Caterham obstinately. 'People who are likely to do that sort of thing oughtn't to be asked to stay. And you may say what you like, Bundle. I don't like inquests. I never have and I never shall.'

'Well, this wasn't the same sort of thing as the last one,' said Bundle soothingly. 'I mean, it wasn't a murder.'

'It might have been—from the fuss that thick-head of an inspector made. He's never got over that business four years ago. He thinks every death that takes place here must necessarily be a case of foul play fraught with grave political significance. You've no idea the fuss he made. I've been hearing about it from Fredwell. Tested everything imaginable for fingerprints. And of course they only found the dead man's own. The clearest case imaginable—though whether it was suicide or accident is another matter.'

'I met Gerry Wade once,' said Bundle. 'He was a friend of Bill's. You'd have liked him, Father. I never saw anyone more cheerfully inefficient than he was. 'I don't like anyone who comes and dies in my house on purpose to annoy me,' said Lord Caterham obstinately.

'But I certainly can't imagine anyone murdering him,' continued Bundle. 'The idea's absurd.'

'Of course it is,' said Lord Caterham. 'Or would be to anyone but an ass like Inspector Raglan.'

'I daresay looking for fingerprints made him feel important,' said Bundle soothingly. 'Anyway, they brought it in 'Death by misadventure,' didn't they?' Lord Caterham acquiesced.

'Oh! don't let's all be subtle,' cried Socks. 'What are we to do about these clocks?'

'Here's Pongo coming back again. Let's ask him,' suggested Jimmy.

Pongo, urged to bring his great brain to bear upon the matter, gave his decision.

'Wait till he's gone to bed and got to sleep. Then enter the room very quietly and put the clocks down on the floor.'

'Little Pongo's right again,' said Jimmy. 'On the word one all park clocks, and then we'll go downstairs and disarm suspicion.'

Bridge was still proceeding—with a slight difference. Sir Oswald was now playing with his wife and was conscientiously pointing out to her the mistakes she had made during the play of each hand. Lady Coote accepted reproof good-humouredly, and with a complete lack of any real interest. She reiterated, not once but many times:

'I see, dear. It's so kind of you to tell me.'

And she continued to make exactly the same errors.

At intervals, Gerald Wade said to Pongo:

'Well played, partner, jolly well played.'

Bill Eversleigh was making calculations with Ronny Devereux.

'Say he goes to bed about twelve—what do you think we ought to give him—about an hour?'

He yawned.

'Curious thing—three in the morning is my usual time for bye-bye, but to-night, just because I know we've got to sit up a bit, I'd give anything to be a mother's boy and turn in right away.'

Everyone agreed that he felt the same.

'My dear Maria,' rose the voice of Sir Oswald in mild irritation, 'I have told you over and over again not to hesitate when you are wondering whether to finesse or not. You give the whole table information.'

Lady Coote had a very good answer to this—namely that as Sir Oswald was dummy, he had no right to comment on the play of the hand. But she did not make it. Instead she smiled kindly, leaned her ample chest well forward over the table, and gazed firmly into Gerald Wade's hand where he sat on her right. Her anxieties lulled to rest by perceiving the queen, she played the knave and took the trick and proceeded to lay down her cards.